Problem: **John invests at 10% simple interest. He invests 1000 dollars. How much does he have after 3 years?**

Learner persona: **High School, grade 11-12 (age 16-18)**

Step-DPO (baseline)	**SLC-StepDPO** (Ours)
Step 1: First, calculate the annual interest earned by John. Since he invests 1000 at a 10% rate, the annual interest is 1000 x 0.10 = 100 dollars. Step 2: Determine the total interest over 3 years. Multiply the annual interest by the number of years: 100 x 3 = 300 dollars. Step 3: Add the total interest to the principal: 1000 + 300 = 1300 dollars. Final answer: 1300 *Computes year-by-year without a formula - same as a younger learner; not adapted to the level.*	Step 1: Calculate the simple interest. The formula for simple interest is I = P x r x t, where P is the principal, r the annual rate, and t the time in years. With P = 1000, r = 0.10, t = 3: I = 1000 x 0.10 x 3 = 300. Step 2: Add the interest to the principal. The total amount is A = P + I = 1000 + 300 = 1300. Final answer: 1300 *States the general formula I = P r t with formal notation - concise and level-appropriate.*

Figure. Same problem for an advanced high-school learner (greedy decoding, real outputs). Red = under-adapted (no formula); Green = formal, level-appropriate formula. Both reach 1300.